To understand how the Brahmins of Malabar acquired that power we have to go back to their origins. Just as the Tamils have their founding father in the rishi Agastya, so the inhabitants of the Deccan's western seaboard have their counterpart in the person of Parashurama.

Parashurama has a more godlike background than Agastya, being the sixth avatar of Lord Vishnu. He is also more violent, as the wielder of a terrible fiery axe, *Parashu*, gifted to him by Lord Shiva, with which he slays innumerable enemies of the gods. Like Agastya, Parashurama features in both the great epics of the *Mahabharata* and *Ramayana*, and in the former we are told how Parashurama rid the world of all the Kshatriyas, not once but twenty-one times over. He then claimed their lands for himself and performed the *ashwamedha yagna* (horse sacrifice) as a sovereign ruler, before handing the land over to the head-priests of the Brahmins for occupation. That is the basic story, which is elaborated further in a later text known as the *Brahmanda Purana*, which can be translated as 'the ancient text of the creation of the world'.

The Puranas were written at a time when rival devotional cults within the broadening church of Hinduism had just begun to compete for popular acceptance – an extended process usually associated with the Gupta era in Northern India (c. 320–550 CE). The *Brahmanda Purana* is reckoned to be among the last of the Puranas to be written, in about the sixth or seventh century. Here we are told that when India's western coast was swamped by the sea Parashurama challenged the god Varuna, who by now had changed from a Vedic deity with responsibility for social order into a god of oceans and rivers. Parashurama threw his mighty axe into the sea, which caused the land to rise up out of the water, but land so salty as to be barren. So Parashurama performed a ritual to summon Nagaraja, the king of the snakes, who covered the land with snake venom, which neutralised the salt and made it fertile. This newly